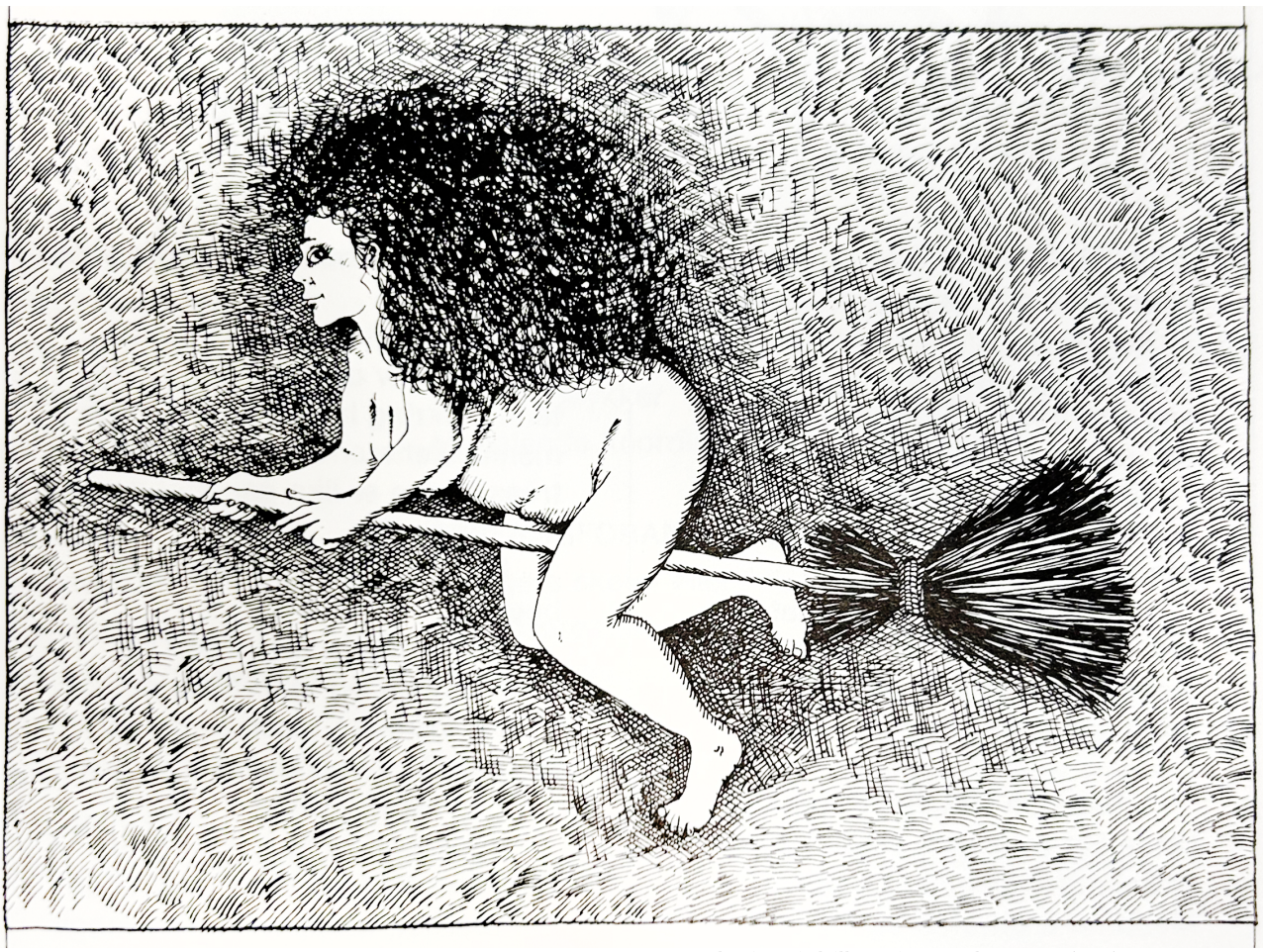
‘Grade-Three Witch’:

The Alchemy of Menstruation



Unnamed artist, Witch illustration, *Hverdagen* No 28 (1980) p. 9. Courtesy of University of Agder.

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Women who become impossible to live with for a few days each month are more to be pitied than blamed, and they are entitled to more help from the medical profession than they are getting, declared Dr Erie *(sic.)* Henriksen, a surgeon-gynecologist who is head of the University of Southern California’s Department of Gynecology. The women in point, whom he described as ‘part-time witches’, are victims of premenstrual tension. […] They classify them as grade-one, grade-two and grade-three witches, according to the severity of their symptoms. A grade-three witch, he said frankly, is a woman to be avoided on her bad days unless she gets effective treatment.[1]

So began the October 1956 article ‘Witches Every Month’ in *TIME* magazine.[2] Perhaps his comments about witchery were meant to be funny? Or provocative? Whatever the case for Henriksen’s invocation of the witch, he meant it as a decidedly *bad* thing. He framed it as a pathology to be diagnosed and “un-witched” through treatment. Henriksen’s treatment of women diagnosed with what is known as premenstrual tension (PMS) and premenstrual dysphoric disorder (PMDD) went far beyond addressing hormonal fluctuations. His regimen included a combination of psychotherapy, sedatives, hormone injections, and strict instructions on weight control – often blaming symptoms on what he saw as poor personal habits rather than considering broader physiological or social factors. He encouraged dieting and labeled overweight women as particularly susceptible to mood-related symp-

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toms, reinforcing damaging stereotypes about emotional instability and body size. The pharmaceutical treatments he prescribed included estrogen and progesterone, often given in untested combinations, alongside barbiturates and tranquilizers, reflecting a medical culture more invested in controlling women's behavior than understanding their lived experiences. In his time, Henriksen treated over 400 patients for premenstrual tension in the postwar decades.

In this article, I am taking Henriksen's spooky comments as a point of investigation into the modern and contemporary intersections of witchcraft and the menstrual cycle. I explore examples of creative projects and artworks that combine witchcraft and menstruation since the 1980s, drawing upon the fields of Critical Menstruation Studies, Neopagan Studies, and Art History. While this article focuses on artistic responses since the 1980s, these works resonate with a much older association between menstruation, magic, and marginalization—stretching from early modern witch trials to feminist reinterpretations of the witch figure in the 1970s and beyond.[3] Conclusively, I argue that contemporary artists reframe menstruation as a source of transformative power, challenging historic stigmas by invoking magic, science, and feminist theory in equal measure.

The menstrual cycle and witchcraft in the arts

In her visual history of the witch, Pam Grossman shows us how visual culture has played a role in the survival of the witch lore and tradition, and the continued global fascination with the archetype.[4] Jessica Hundley provides a working definition of the witch, past and present:

> "The archetype of the witch is in a state of constant evolution. The foundations of witchcraft are murky, its history hidden and suppressed. The archaic brutality of the witch hunts remains resonant even now – fear manifested as judgement; ignorance exhibited through violence. And yet, the witch not only endures, but thrives, a symbolic embodiment of victory, of the triumph of magick over the tyranny of oppression."[5]

This twenty-first century definition barely leaves room for Henriksen's use of the term witch, which is decidedly negative and fearful, and certainly not "a symbolic embodiment of victory". In this reading, it is Henriksen, as a symbol of the patriarchal medical tradition, who is the oppressor. While Henriksen's views on witches were unusual even in his own time, his framing of what is now understood as premenstrual syndrome (PMS) reflects a medical paradigm increasingly challenged by contemporary health professionals, menstrual health advocates, and scholars in Critical Menstruation Studies; an interdisciplinary scholarly field defined in 2020 as research that critically examines all aspects of the cycle, including related culture, history and arts.[6] Recent discourse – including proposals from within the World Health Organization – has begun to consider the menstrual cycle as a potential vital sign, not in the sense of essential for health, but as a meaningful physiological indicator akin to pulse or blood pressure, encompassing conditions like PMS within a broader understanding of menstrual health.[7]

So, as witches have been reclaimed by feminists, neopagans and Wiccans, and menstrual and PMS stigma is increasingly being challenged, where does this leave the connection between the menstrual cycle and magic? These connections raise questions about whether spiritual practices like cycle spells can coexist with empirical frameworks – or whether they risk undermining the medical legitimacy hardwon by menstruation researchers.

While the spiritual approach to the menstrual cycle continues to be in tension with scientific readings, artists have blended these approaches. Since the 1960s, menstrual art emerged as a small, but influential genre aligned with other fields including Feminist, Performance, and Body art. Here, menstrual themes including PMS and blood were explored as material, inspiration, oddity, beauty, gore, and for shock value. While not expressed magic or Wiccan in nature, several early menstrual artworks took on aspects of ritual, especially in the collecting of blood and in works focused on the potential power of the cycle, including emotions and feelings connected to PMS. We now turn to some examples of modern and contemporary art that engage with themes of witches and menstrual magic more directly.

First, let us consider another example of the witch archetype to illustrate menstrual cycle science, but in a decidedly more positive way than Henriksen. In a special 1980 issue on menstruation, PMS and menopause in the Norwegian sexual education magazine *Hverdagen* ('the everyday'), a reoccurring black and white illustration of a witch reappears throughout. This is the witch in her 'hag' style, post-menopausal, with wild hair, naked, and on a broom. The magazine includes articles on menstrual hormones, lore and the price of tampons and pads, while an article on menstrual witches argues that the very reason for the witch trials were connected to fear of menstrual blood. This references the findings of writers like Penelope Shuttle and Peter Redgrove who traced menstruation's symbolic role in early magical traditions and controversially described the witch trials as "nine million menstrual murders", a claim that, while historically disputed, signals a broader feminist effort to foreground menstruation as both feared and powerful.[8]

Invoking the hag-witch archetype in a discussion of menstrual science suggests an embrace of PMS, where the perceived annoying, nagging, insane older woman is reclaimed as an empowered figure who, despite of and due to changing emotions and hormones, has much to contribute to the world. This imagery of the hag-witch – wild-haired, post-menopausal, and airborne – recalls early modern representations of female disorder and reproductive deviance that were central to witchcraft accusations in the 15th to 17th centuries.[9]

Rather than leaning into the scientific visualization and representation of menstruation found in other Scandinavian educational pamphlets and textbooks at the time, the editors selected a more creative solution by working with a professional artist who linked menstrual stigma to the idea of the



Heks over alle hauger
- til alle tider

• Like gammel som Eva selv

En heks er en kvinne med merkelige evner.

Hun rir til sabbaten på et kosteskaft, hun har ånder som elskere, hun tilber månens guddommelighet. Evnene kan brukes til godt og vondt, forbannelse og velsignelse.

«En heks kan skape plutselig sykdom, mentale forstyrrelser, ulykker, død — på mann, kvinne, barn. En heks kan forderve ekteskap — påføre kvinner sterilitet eller aborter, menn impotens. Hun kan få buskap til å sykne og dø, forårsake storm, hagl og regn som ødelegger avling, det som gror.»

Slik beskrives heksen i en eldre historisk kilde. Les deretter dette: «Hvis... de nærmer seg eller

Fortsetter på neste side

Unnamed artist, Witch illustration, *Hverdagen* No 28 (1980) p. 9. Courtesy of University of Agder.

witch trials as pure misogynistic terror. While no-one was being convicted for witchcraft in 1980s Norway, the text and images suggest that menstrual, PMS and menopause stigma is the last remaining sticky aftermath of the witch trials pure hatred for women's bodies and knowledge. There is a need, even in this highly science-infused publication, to go beyond frameworks like biology, history and sociology to explain why, for example, menstrual blood was still so taboo and why menstrual diseases and PMS were not researched or understood. The necessary framework became the witch. But written after the twentieth-century feminist and neopagan reclamation of the witch as an empowered figure, the publication also suggests that menstruators perhaps have something to gain from seeing their cycle as supernatural, tied to a long tradition of magic, and a deep history of women-centered mythology. Since the menstrual cycle has not been respected or understood, the illustrator connects it to the contemporary reclaimed figure of the witch as a symbol of mystical and even powerful femininity. Here the witch-cycle-art nexus centers on the idea that the traditions of medicine and science are useful but not complete tools by which to understand menstrual cycle. Menstruators need a lore of their own, not contaminated by figures like Henriksen.

In our next example, *A Biomenstrual Spellbook* from 2020, we see a similar creative grappling with the intersections of science and the menstrual cycle, this time through issues of environmentalism.[10] Or, more precisely, the project builds



Nadia Campo Woytuk, Marie Louise Juul Søndergaard, Prototypes for a Biomenstrual Spellbook, 2020s. Courtesy of artist.

on the 'environmenstrualist' movement, a late-twentieth century activist position focused on the intersecting issues of menstruation and environmentalism.[11] This included menstrual product development and waste management, and 'environmenstrualists' therefore historically used tools of scientific enquiry to understand and counter the negative impacts of the menstrual product industry. In *A Biomenstrual Spellbook* this tradition is carried on, but with the addition of magical, creative and witchcraft-adjacent ideas, referencing and building on a larger group of works, spells and science by the Bio Art Coven.[12]

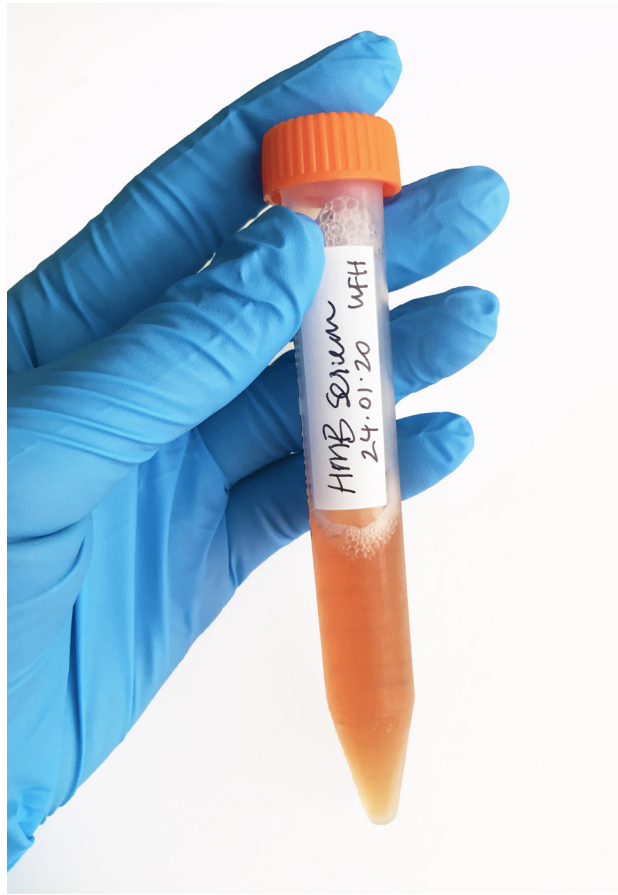
In contrast to earlier 'environmenstrualist' projects, the creators were not solely focused on the menstrual product industry. Rather, theirs was a holistic view of natural cycles, where, for example, menstrual blood could fertilize soil and organisms, which in turn would improve microenvironments and create plants like moss to be used in biodegradable and safe menstrual pads. Rejecting both the menstrual product industry, its products, and its methods, the project envisioned instead a world where human and non-human organisms could benefit from the menstrual cycle, and where the menstrual cycle in turn became precious – not as a commodity or something to control, but as a phenomenon for positive change in the natural world.[13] Here, the changes of the menstrual cycle, including PMS, work as a metaphor for change in general. The authors experimented with science and witchcraft methodologies in laboratories and kitchens, inside and outside, offering information, recipes for biodegradable pads, and spells for menstrual and environmental wellbeing. Richly illustrated with drawings and photographs, the book included images of people watering plants with blood, self-made biodegradable pad experiments with algae, and a sketch for a speculative menstrual blood receptacle. The latter was an attempt to imagine a world where menstrual blood is precious, as suggested by feminist witches like Starhawk fifty

years prior:[14] "Now my body, in all its femaleness, its breasts, vulva, womb, and menstrual flow, was sacred."[15]

If menstrual blood was valued, asked the authors, what objects would we then use for collection and storage? The canisters they create are inspired by seashells, made with glass, and adorned with various corks that could act as a mister, making it possible to use menstrual blood as a fertilizer. In these ways, *A Biomenstrual Spellbook* functions as a utopic projection for menstruators, imagining a world where the menstrual cycle is not just destigmatized and accepted, but valued for its transformational power and place in the larger ecosystem. Utilizing methods that invoke both creative play, design, lab-based science, arts and witchcraft, the project suggests a future in which the spiritual and scientific readings of the menstrual cycle could benefit from each other.

A similar grappling with science, art and witchcraft is found in *Mooncalf*, a multi-disciplinary project by WhiteFeather Hunter from the late 2010s to the early 2020s. Hunter is both an artist and scientist with deep knowledge of menstrual magic history. In 2024, she further developed her project as part of *Arcanum Sanguinis: Occult Blood*, an exhibition she curated at the Museum of Witchcraft and Magic.[16] The show situated her work within a wider investigation of occult knowledge systems, alchemical practices, and biotechnological embodiment. For the *Mooncalf* project, she collected and transformed her own menstrual blood into blood serum to explore the potential to grow cells from this concoction, inspired by the lab-grown meat trend.[17] *Mooncalf* crossed the science-magic-art line, utilizing the medical laboratory environment that would have been familiar to Henriksen, and the creative utopian imagining of feminist witchcraft and SciArt; an artistic genre expresses scientific themes in works of art. The project makes viewers consider complicated ethical problems like the regulations surrounding menstrual blood in laboratory settings, and cannibalism.

Hunter's work faced constant institutional barriers, many of them rooted in the medical paradigm and certainty stemming from Henriksen's time. For instance, Hunter had to classify her own menstrual blood as biotoxins, carrying it around in locked sample box. While her project was able to penetrate the world of science (Hunter is a scientist, worked in laboratories as part of the project, and finalized her PhD), the process made her own menstrual blood into a scientific sample. *Mooncalf* also saw the laboratory space infused with magical ritual, and the scientific equipment exhibited in an art gallery. Wrestling back control from the scientific paradigm, *Mooncalf's* speculative, mystical, creative and scientifically rigorous methodologies did coexist together, often in a clash. For instance, the idea of making meat for consumption with menstrual cells is unlikely, but the very idea (a fabulation) challenged the scientific institution, laboratory and academic boundaries to broaden when it came to defining what is real menstrual cycle science – and therefore knowledge. If menstrual science can also be art and witchcraft, as demonstrated by *Mooncalf*, things have certainly changed since the time of Henriksen. The project in many ways reclaimed the figure of the witch as a negative and unpowered person



WhiteFeather Hunter, menstrual serum, part of the *Mooncalf* project, 2020s. Courtesy of artists.

within Henriksen's misogynistic worldview, and placed her in the lab, making knowledge alongside him, while menstruating, PMS-ing and cycling through the month.

In the three examples explored above, we see an argument about the positive transformative qualities of menstrual cycling appear. In the 1980 illustrations of witches, the witch is a figure of creativity, power, and joy in an otherwise rather dire scientific paradigm consisting of facts about what is and is not normal. In *Biomenstrual: A spell book for more-than-human menstrual care*, the creators refuse the scientific and capitalist paradigm of the menstrual product industry, turning instead to the cycles of nature for utopic potential and magical transformation. And in *Mooncalf,* science transforms menstrual blood and experiences into new things, like meat and new institutional knowledge – as well as firmly placing, perhaps for the first time so clearly, the witch in the menstrual science lab. All of this is a retort to Henriksen's claim, because in these projects the witch is both real, in control or an archetype that is empowering.

The menstrual cycle transformed

Henriksen's commentary in the October 1956 *TIME* article, 'Witches Every Month', positioned women experiencing premenstrual tension as "grade-three witches", a characterization intended as both diagnosis and insult. While rooted

in misogynistic rhetoric, Henriksen inadvertently pinpointed a powerful cultural archetype – the witch – that resonates across histories of gendered medicine, art, and feminist reclamations of embodiment.

Magic can be defined as the use of symbolic, ritualistic, or spiritual practices to invoke change through non-material means. Scholars of menstruation have shown how early texts mentioning menstruation, such as Pliny's *Natural History*, saw menstruation in this way – menstrual blood could be used to invoke negative change in the world, turning crops barren for instance.[18] Henriksen likewise asserts that the menstrual cycle can invoke negative change on his patients. In contrast, artists combining menstrual and witchcraft themes explore the possibility of using the cycle to invoke positive change in the world. In their works, menstrual experiences becomes a creative force, an empowering phenomenon, and something that can have natural and supernatural influence.

The projects explored in this article demonstrate that menstruation can be reimagined as transformative – not only in the biological sense, but in cultural, spiritual, and epistemological terms. Where Henriksen pathologized premenstrual experience as a temporary loss of control – classifying women as "grade-three witches" to be treated or avoided – contemporary artists reclaim the figure of the witch as a symbol of embodied power, knowledge, and creative potential. While severe menstrual symptoms such as PMS and PMDD warrant medical attention, the rhetoric and framework advanced by Henriksen reflect a patriarchal medical paradigm that many artists and activists now seek to critique and transcend.

In the artworks discussed, science and magic are not mutually exclusive but coexistent ways of knowing. The menstrual body becomes a site for speculation, ritual, and experimentation – one that challenges narrow definitions of health and proposes more expansive ways of understanding menstruation's role in both human and more-than-human systems. Rather than conforming to normative biomedical standards, these projects question who has historically defined the "normal" menstrual body and offer alternative visions shaped by feminist, ecological, and magical perspectives.

By integrating scientific practice with ritual aesthetics and speculative design, these artists do not merely illustrate a shift in how menstruation is represented – they participate in reshaping the epistemic structures around it. In doing so, they complicate the legacy of medical authority and reposition the menstrual body as a site of agency, knowledge production, and imaginative transformation.

1 'Medicine: Witches Every Month', *TIME* magazine, 22 October 1956.

2 Suzanne Latham was the first to write critically about the *TIME* article in *Witches Every Month? The Social Construction of Premenstrual Syndrome* (Master thesis: Western Michigan University, 1990).

3 While early feminist readings emphasized the misogyny of witch hunts – sometimes interpreting them as direct attacks on female reproductive knowledge – recent historiography offers a more nuanced view, noting the varied motives behind accusations, including local politics, economics, and social tensions. B. Ehrenreich, D. English, *Witches, Midwives, & Nurses: A History of Women Healers* (New York 1973); K. Green, J. Bigelow, 'Does Science Persecute Women? The Case of the 16th-17th Century Witch-Hunts', *Philosophy* Vol 73, No 2 (1998) 195-217; R. Horsley, 'Who Were the Witches? The Social Roles of the Accused in the European Witch Trials', *Journal of Interdisciplinary History* Vol. 9, No. 4 (1979) 689-715; F. Lang, 'Witches, Midwives, Nurses' *Off Our Backs* Vol. 3, No. 3, (1972) 27; A. Gottlieb Thomas, *Blood Magic. The Anthropology of Menstruation* (Berkeley/ Los Angeles/ London 1988). On reproductive care and midwifery during the witch trials see B.P. Levack (ed.), *Oxford handbook of Witchcraft in Early Modern Europe and Colonial America* (Oxford 2013) 127, 191, 244.

4 P. Grossman, *The Library of Esotherica: Witchcraft* (London 2021) 8.

5 J. Hundley, 'Preface' in: Grossman, *The Library of Esotherica: Witchcraft*, 8.

6 C. Bobel e.a., (eds.) *Palgrave Handbook of Critical Menstruation Studies* (Palgrave 2020).

7 A.K. Rosen Vollmar, S. Mahalingaiah, A.M. Jukic, 'The menstrual cycle as a vital sign: A comprehensive review', *Fertility and sterility Reviews* Vol 6, No 1 (2025).

8 P. Shuttle, P. Redgrove, *The Wise Wound: Menstruation & Everywoman* (Paladin 1986, first published 1978) 197-198. See also J. Delaney, M.J. Lipton, E. Tooth, *The Curse: A Cultural History of Menstruation* (Illinois 1988, first published 1976) 42.

9 L.C. Hults, *The Witch as Muse: Art, Gender, and Power in Early Modern Europe* (Philadelphia 2005).

10 N. Campo Woytuk, M.L. Juul Søndergaard, *Biomenstrual: A Spellbook for more-than-human menstrual care* (2021): https://files.persona.co/108249/Biomenstrual-spellbook.pdf

11 The word 'environmenstrualism' seems to have been coined by the British organization Women's Environmental Network in the late 1980s, see 'Our History', *Women's Environmental Network* website (2025): https://www.wen.org.uk/our-history/

12 BioArt Coven, 'BioArt Coven Manifesto', *Occult Studies* Vol. 2: Revolution (2021): https://snakehair.com/shop/occult-studies-volume-2-revolution

13 Woytuk, Søndergaard, 'Feminist Posthumanist Design of Menstrual Care for More-than-Human Bodies', *Proceedings of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems* No 38 (2023) 1-18.

14 Emerging from the broader Wiccan revival of the 1940s and 50s, feminist authors like Starhawk infused modern witchcraft with a focus on menstruation, bodily autonomy, and ecological spirituality. Starhawk, *The Spiral Dance*, introduction to the 10t anniversary edition, 1999, first published 1979.

15 Starhawk, *The Spiral Dance*, introduction to the 10t anniversary edition.

16 W.F. Hunter, H. Kenyon, *Arcanum Sanguinis: Occult Blood - Science and medicine underwritten by witchcraft and magic; from the collection of the Museum of Witchcraft and Magic* (Boscastle, UK: Harbour Witch Imprint – forthcoming).

17 Hunter, *The Witch in the Lab Coat - Doubling, Doubling, Toiling and Troubling the Narratives and Methodologies of Standard Scientific Research Practices* (Leonardo Graduate Abstracts, US: Leonardo/ Arizona State University, 2024); Hunter, 'Mooncalf Menstrual Meat (MMM)', *Continuum: Journal of Media & Cultural Studies* (AU: Cultural Studies Association of Australasia, 2023), 576-594.

18 For longer histories of religious and spiritual approaches to menstruation see R.R. Wasserfall (ed.) *Women and Water: Menstruation in Jewish Life and Law* (Brandeis 1999); S. Barkataki, 'Memory and Imagination: Reclaiming Menstruation' in: F. Ahamed (ed.), *Period Matters: Menstruation in South Asia* (Palgrave 2022).